play at the next level." Originally from Ferozepur, Punjab, Singh is an Indian citizen, one who has already fulfilled his dream to represent India and wear the national colours. However, there are a number of other players on India Rising who have great talent but won't be allowed a chance to represent their motherland due to their NRI status. India doesn't allow for dual nationality and, unlike a number of competing nations in Asia and around the world, the Indian basketball team can't play 'naturalised' foreign players in their basketball squad.

For players like Inderbir Gill, Sukhmail Mathon, Kiran Shastri, Aryan Sharma, Josh Sharma, Sai Tummala and Varun Ram, India Rising offers an opportunity to represent their ethnic roots at a grand stage. "We really do feel like this is possibly the greatest team of Indians ever organised," says Gill, 34, who was born in Hoshiarpur in Punjab before his family moved to the US. "Hopefully, we can start a tradition so that there can be an India Rising team at the TBT every year." Shastri, 26, who grew up in San Francisco, California, adds, "For us, this is the closest thing we might get to playing for the national team."

But the TBT is only a peek at India Rising's ambitions. The path ahead will include a 'block party' in New Delhi later this year to raise more awareness about the sport, a development camp in India and a docuseries about desi ballers. "India Rising is so much bigger than the game of basketball," says Navin Ramharak, the brand's chief operating officer. "This is about changing the culture, about breaking stereotypes, about finally telling all of the stories of our heroes that have never been told." ■

–Karan Madhok

SPORTS

India's Future Fighters

In a recent global tournament, a new generation of Indian women wrestlers announced their arrival

There wasn't a hint of nerves as Savita Dalal squared up for her first final in her first-ever international tournament. The 16-year-old Indian, dressed in the team's orange colours, went straight for her opponent's leg to throw her off-balance, moving into a 4-0 lead within 15 seconds. Savita maintained the aggression throughout and, with over a minute left on the clock, pinned Uzbekistan's Ulmeken Esenbaeva to win the bout 8-4.

Savita's win in the 61 kg final exemplified the Indian team's fearless performance at the Asian Cadet Championships (U-17) in Bikshek, Kyrgyzstan, which concluded in June. The Indian women, who won eight golds, medalled in all the 10 weight categories. "It is the first time in any international competition that we have won eight golds in 10 events. It is a remarkable achievement," says coach Shyam Budaki. "Importantly, women from Japan have been dominating these events, and we beat them." With 235 points, India finished on the top of the table, ahead of wrestling superpower Japan.

The triumph marked the arrival of a new generation of Indian female wrestlers. Apart from Priya, who won gold in the 73 kg category, all the girls were participating in their first international tournament. They didn't let the stage or the opponents, especially those from Japan, intimidate them. With their close-cropped hair, physical intensity and confidence, they looked competition-ready.



Courtesy SAI/TWITTER

Even though wrestling is now a high-profile Olympic event in India, it remains a small-town sport. Seven members of India's U-17 team came from the cradle of Indian wrestling—Haryana—while there were two from Delhi and one from Maharashtra. Like Savita, most of them come from families who rely on farming as their main source of income.

> Indian women won eight golds and medalled in all the 10 weight categories at the **ASIAN CADET CHAMPIONSHIPS (U-17)**

"When I was younger, I would help out my father in the sugarcane farm," says Savita, who hails from a wrestling family in Rohtak. "My grandfather and father used to wrestle, too. I am currently living with my uncle and cousin who are also into the sport." At 16, she is already living the disciplined life of a wrestler. Her seven-hour training day begins at 5.30 in the morning.

Coach Budaki believes the younger generation is now coming in with a great deal of awareness. Since Sushil Kumar won the bronze medal at Beijing 2008, Indian wrestlers have medalled in all the subsequent Olympic editions. The success of the Phogat sisters and Sakshi Malik's Olympic breakthrough at Rio 2016 have raised the bar for female wrestlers. "There has been a sea-change in women's wrestling in the country in the past 3-4 years," he says. "Earlier, just to compete on the international level was a big deal. Now these girls have locked in on a target. They all want to compete at the Olympics. Whoever takes up wrestling is doing it with the aspiration of winning an Olympic medal."

While a lot may yet depend on how they graduate to a more senior level, the Asian Cadet Championships gave an encouraging glimpse into India's wrestling future. ■

–Deepti Patwardhan